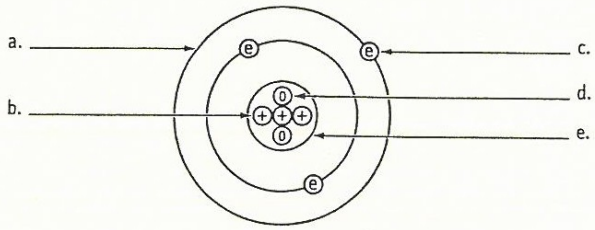
Atomic structure 8a

Note: You will need to refer to a copy of the periodic table for this worksheet.

A popular atomic model

Many people today believe that atoms can be described by the atomic model of the solar system atom. This orbital atomic model allows us to explain many processes.

The atom is made up of three main subatomic particles which are grouped into two lots. Protons and neutrons are tightly packed into the nucleus which forms the centre of the atom. Electrons surround the nucleus on several orbits (or shells).



1 Label the diagram of an atomic model (lithium).

Subatomic particles

Protons and neutrons are 2000 times heavier than electrons. Protons and electrons have an electric charge: protons are positive and electrons are negative. Electrons fly around the nucleus on orbits. Neutrons and protons rest in the nucleus.

2 Complete the table about subatomic particles.

Name	Charge	Mass	Position	Movement
			on orbits	
		2000 times		
	neutral			no

Atomic numbers and mass numbers, atoms and isotopes

Atoms are neutral, although some of their subatomic particles do have an electric charge. But the positive and negative subatomic charges cancel each other leaving the atom neutral. Therefore, the number of positive protons must equal the number of negative electrons. The *atomic number* gives the number of protons.

Since protons and neutrons are very much heavier than electrons, it is the protons and neutrons which determine the mass of the atoms. Usually an atom has as many neutrons as protons. The *mass number* is the sum of protons and neutrons.

Some elements have atoms which have the same number of protons in the nucleus (so the same atomic number) but more or fewer neutrons (so they have different atomic weights). Their atoms are now called *isotopes*.

When the number of neutrons is much larger than the number of protons in a large nucleus, the isotope's nucleus is unstable. As a result it breaks up, forming new atoms and giving off radiation.

3 Complete the table about mass and atomic numbers of atoms.

Name	Mass number	Atomic number	Number of protons	Number of neutrons	Number of electrons	Scientific notation
lithium	5	3	3	2	3	$^{5}_{3}Li$
magnesium	24				12	
aluminium		13		13		
hydrogen	1					
chlorine						$^{35}_{17}Cl$
phosphorus						$^{31}_{15}P$
oxygen						$^{16}_{8}O$